Maintaining Safety and Health in Shelters

Guidance for workers at shelters on keeping people healthy and safe

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers, Disaster Health Services

Considerations

- Keeping everyone safe is our priority.
- Natural hazards, facility hazards, safety concerns and poor environmental health threaten client and worker safety.
- The Shelter Site Manager and all shelter workers are responsible for identifying and responding to all potential health and safety hazards.
- Congregate shelters may increase the risk of exposure to infectious diseases for our clients and workforce.
- While Red Cross maintains responsibility to manage the shelter, public health authorities maintain the legal responsibility and authority to act involving infectious disease and public health.
- It's natural that the close living environment for individuals from different families and communities may lead to people feeling unsafe.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
  - Shelter Operations
  - Household Pets and Service Animals
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards

What to do

Prepare for emergencies at the shelter

- Complete the **Safety in Shelters/Emergency Action Plan** within 72 hours of opening.
- Brief the staff and keep the plan available in case of an emergency.
- Identify the location of first-aid kits, AEDs, fire extinguishers and emergency supplies.
- Order necessary safety items that are not already on site.

Inspect the facility

- Conduct shelter shift **inspections** at the beginning of each shift.
- Inspect inside and outside frequently to identify potentially dangerous situations or issues. Check for the following issues:
  - Lack of accessibility
  - Signs of excessive wear and tear
  - Obstructed emergency exits
  - Any hazards, including fire or trip hazards
  - Obstructed aisles or inaccessible routes within the shelter
  - Areas in need of cleaning
  - Inadequate lighting
  - Damaged or illegible signage that needs to be replaced, especially after heavy wind or rain

Report safety issues identified in the shelter inspection

- The Shift Supervisor or designated individual fills out the **Shift Inspection Form**.
- The Shelter Site Manager reviews, prioritizes, and records what needs to be addressed in the Daily Shelter Report, or other appropriate tool.

Respond to facility hazards

- Mark holes, loose tiles, exposed wiring, or liquid on the floors with a safety cone or floor sign, and caution tape.
- Assign a worker to guard the area until it can be addressed if the hazard is severe.
- Mop up any spills if custodial staff isn't present.
- Immediately report hazards requiring facility action to HQ Sheltering Manager who reports the hazard to the facility owner and the Logistics section.

Respond to injuries to clients, workers, visitors and animals housed at the shelter

- When an injury occurs or is reported, request assistance from onsite Disaster Health Services or EMTs assigned to the shelter.
    - In the event of serious injuries, immediately contact 911 and provide emergency first-aid until their arrival.

- In the event of injuries to animals housed at the shelter, the Shelter Site Manager immediately contacts the animal welfare agency on site, or the Pet Services Coordinator, to arrange for appropriate veterinary care.
- In the event of injuries caused by household pets or service animals:
    - Immediately obtain medical support for the injury.
    - The animal welfare agency confines the animal and notifies the jurisdiction's animal control officer (ACO). If there is no animal welfare partner on site, the Shelter Site Manager should inform the Pet Services Coordinator and request they notify the ACO or Department of Health.
    - Shelter Site Manager immediately informs the pet owner of the incident and that the animal is being confined for observation.

- The Shelter Site Manager or designee documents all details of accidents and injuries including names of witnesses and the details of the response.
    - Seek direction from Headquarters on any additional requirements for reporting.

Respond to infectious diseases at the shelter

- Work closely with Disaster Health Services and public health officials to determine what steps need to be taken when a client has a suspected or confirmed communicable disease.
- Report any signs of food-related illness to Disaster Health Services.
    - Use **Responding to Norovirus f**or guidance in handling norovirus.

- During a pandemic or other public health emergency:
    - Follow all protocols as directed by Public Health.
    - Confirm there are enough sanitation and safety supplies for the next few days of shelter operations.
    - Stay current with the latest precautionary guidance and protocols.
    - Educate clients and shelter staff about disease prevention measures.
    - Establish an isolation care area when directed to do so by Disaster Health Services.
    - Follow Public Health sanitation guidance when closing the shelter.

Respond to bed bugs and lice infestations at the shelter

- See **Responding to Bed Bugs** for guidance in handling bed bugs.
- See **Responding to Lice** for guidance in handling lice.

Keep the shelter clean

- Clean and sanitize the shelter regularly.
  - Advise HQ Sheltering Manager when outside janitorial/cleaning services is needed.
- Provide hand washing stations and hand sanitizer throughout the shelter, especially in high traffic areas and at the start of the food service line.
- Pick up litter and empty the trash.
- Sanitize all high-touch areas with disinfectant at the beginning of each shift.
  - Wipe down the dormitory registration and servicedesks, light switches, door handles and push plates.
  - Clean and sanitize the food serviceand dining areas before and after meals.
- Clean restrooms and showers as often as necessary.
- Clean and inspectused cots.

Maintain sanitation and regular cleaning in the pet services area

- Ensure hand washing stations are available.
- Empty waste receptacles frequently in pet room and relief areas.
- Clean floors using appropriate animal-safe cleaner.

Establish refuge areas at the shelter

- Designate a refuge area for people to take temporary refuge during threats such as gale force winds or tornadoes.
  - Identify a safe space located in an interior enclosed hallway or room if possible, which offer the most protection.
  - Allocate a minimum of 15 square feet for every person in the shelter (clients and workers)
  - Be sure to identify this area in the Emergency Action Plan
  - Address concerns for people who feel unsafe around animals

Fears related to animals

- Establish methods to enable clients and workers who feel unsafe near pets to remain separated from animals.

Related Articles

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Identifying the Safest Refuge Area at a Shelter
Guidance for workers at shelters on establishing a location for clients and workers for temporary protection from danger

Gather and Share Essential Information to Support the Initiation of Sheltering
Guidance for sheltering leadership at DRO Headquarters on the data and information that supports the start of shelter operations

Prepare for Daily Sheltering Coordination Meeting
Guidance for sheltering leadership at DRO Headquarters on necessary actions to take in advance of the daily sheltering coordination meeting

Supporting DRO leadership in Coordinating and Prioritizing Sheltering
Guidance for sheltering leadership at DRO Headquarters to enable our mission essential function of sheltering to be the priority of all DRO leadership

Maintaining Security at the Shelter
Guidance for workers in shelters on establishing and maintaining a secure and safe operating location

Sheltering Toolkit